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Analysing George Orwell‘s messages regarding totalitarianism in the settings of ‘1984’

Research Question : How does Orwell use setting to communicate the dangers of a totalitarian society?

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Table of Contents

Introduction **3**

Victory Mansions **4**

Divided Society (Proles) **6**

Social Hierarchy 6

Proles 7

Sanctuary **9**

Pub 9

Golden Country 11

Cafe 13

Government **14**

Ministries 14

Technology 15

Power (‘Big Brother’ and Torture Chambers) 16

Conclusion **17**

Works Cited **18**

Introduction

George Orwell was born Eric Arthur Blair in 1903 to English parents in Bengal, his father being a worker in the opium trade industry. After spending most of his formative years at Eton, a prestigious boarding school in England, he joined the imperial police in Burma in 1922. In 'Why I Write,' he gives insight into his years in the "unsuitable profession" of the imperial force, rejecting imperialism and subsequent experience with poverty after his return to Britain. Conscious to colonialism's many evils, and "fully aware of the existence of the working classes," he began the creation of a "political orientation." The publication of Down and Out in Paris and London in 1933, saw him change his name to George Orwell **[Woodcock]**. His most famous novels seek to show the ways that many government structures are prone to totalitarianism, and they portray the gradual, often unnoticeable descent into that totalitarianism.

'1984' is a novel in this vein, published in 1949 by George Orwell as a message to the Western World regarding the dangers of totalitarianism, and the importance of free thought and speech. This novel is considered very controversial, having been banned in Belarus, Soviet Russia, as well as parts of the United States **[Doyle]**, ironically by governments on both ends of the political spectrum. Mainstream culture has certainly been impacted by the novel due to the extent to which the dystopian tale left a mark on its readers. In particular, its influence and sustained relevance is largely due to the ostensible parallels of various concepts presented in this novel to those in the real world's various social and political problems, inciting fear and distrust in the readers.

The settings that Orwell creates in this novel can be broken down into four main themes : the compromise of home, division of society, sanctuary, and the power of the government. These settings create the foundation for Orwell's depiction of totalitarianism as dangerous for society as a whole ; killing essential elements of humanity such as privacy, by turning our most private space into a key surveillance avenue for those in charge, and devaluing the very idea of a home itself, marginalising, and compromising the sanctity it holds. As a result, this essay aims to answer the question - **How does Orwell use setting to communicate the dangers of a totalitarian society?**

Victory Mansions

The diction in the title of this residential area, 'Victory Mansions', is one that implies superiority, grandeur, and a sense of invincibility, connoting the affluent and powerful image the party broadcasts. However this is immediately juxtaposed with the terribly maintained, stale, and crumbling nature of the apartment complex with the setting of a "gritty dust" being the reader's first foray into the comprehension of this to be a society in decay. This is also representative of the people's lives under this totalitarian regime, as Orwell portrays Winston's living conditions to be miserable.

Apart from his "terrible" 'Victory Gin', Winston has very little food in his flat. Alcohol being a staple for him also implies his wish to distance himself from his current existence and set of circumstances. Orwell uses irony in this beverage's name, as his current existence is very

melancholy, communicating a subtle message about how the totalitarians' "victory" comes about at the expense of everyone working for, or beneath them. Furthermore the impact of this totalitarian society is also shown in the "plaster flaking constantly" and the "pipes bursting", all occurring due to "motives of economy" : drawing a parallel to our current world, with the rich getting richer and the poor getting poorer, reflected in the disparity in their respective quality of life. The diction here is effective in creating rather graphic imagery of a deteriorating household, which is used to establish it as a symbol for the compromising quality of life under this regime, which is already at dire straits and only foreshadows further decomposition of humanity as a whole.

Winton's house is used to establish the premise of where Winston stands with regard to the Party. The prominent presence of the 'Telescreen' is intimidating, and a point of salience in the imagery that Orwell creates of his flat. This is used by the party as a communication and monitoring device, propagating their chosen media, as well as peering into the lives of every individual for the 'Thought Police' to benefit from. This is a symbol for the omniscient presence of the Ingsoc party and 'Big Brother', implicitly establishing their unwavering power and control.

The alcove's position away from the telescreen's view, connotes a slight resistance through a speck of humanity that lives on in Winston despite this overwhelming power of the Party. The alcove's illusion of privacy also plays a role in encouraging his first subversive act, writing in a journal, which he uses to escape from his current life into a 'secret existence' where things are better. Winston's certainty of his demise at the hands of the thought police for merely finding a sense of home in his journal's musings, created through the overall setting and imagery of his

flat, connotes the sheer extent of the threat posed to individualistic freedom, even something as primal as idyllic musing, in a totalitarian society.

Divided Society (Proles)

Social Hierarchy

Orwell depicts very distinct divisions in this society, with three predominantly unique groups of people in London. This is influenced by his own experiences with totalitarian regimes and his observations of the real world, as Orwell found the “real nature of capitalist society” repulsive, having “seen British imperialism at work in Burma” The Inner Party, which is very wealthy, and has luxurious amenities with servants to suit their needs. Winston’s demographic, or The Outer Party is also a group in London, living in some forms of comfort but with no real privacy or control of their personal lives. The Proles are the third group, in this futuristic world, they are the only group without Telescreens from the Party, implying them being considered to be almost beneath ‘humanity’ by the other two groups, living in destitute poverty, in a large slum community. The lives of the proles are notoriously difficult due to the party treating them as subhuman, which is reflected in their compromised housing. This is also another direct parallel to Orwell’s observations of socio-economic divides in London, having “seen something of the effects of poverty and unemployment in Britain.”

Proles

Firstly, the Proles' residential area is known as a 'slum', carrying negative connotations of unwanted and expendable masses. The graphic imagery of "little two-story houses" implies a lack of infrastructural development, a notion furthered by the presence of "battered doorways", connoting negligence and deterioration, providing an implicit commentary on the treatment, and current state of the proles as a people. There is also a semantic field of filth, with Orwell's Diction portraying the Prolish slums as "suggestive of rat holes", with "puddles of filthy water", and "dark doorways". The symbol of "dark doorways" symbolises a lack of 'light' or hope for them to overcome the "filth" that their lives have become in this "rat hole" of a slum compound that they reside in ; effectively communicating Orwell's message of the danger posed to those of lower classes under a totalitarian society, and drawing parallels to the lives of the poor in Orwell's world. Furthermore, the adjectives used to describe the prolish people include, "crude", "ragged", "bent", "angry", and "swollen" to name a few. This diction creates a subtle commentary on the perception that the elites of a totalitarian society have of those 'below' them, which is why the Proles are treated in such an inhumane manner. Moreover, it also carries larger implications of what current society at Orwell's time is becoming ; the commoners being run "ragged" and everyone being "angry" at various ethnicities, nationalities and those of other ideologies after the world wars **[Crash Course]**, effectively creating a sense of relatability for the reader to understand the threat of this being a realistic possible future for our current society.

Winston's stroll through one of the prole neighbourhoods is enlightening for the reader, informing us that bombs falling in these regions is a common occurrence, implying that Proles' lives are considered expendable, and that both sides of the war are indifferent to civilian

casualties ; a subtle link to Orwell's personal belief, that both political extremes on the spectrum ironically hold the same set of beliefs. This is founded in his experience fighting the fascist leader of Spain, Francisco Franco, where he famously didn't join the main communist party as "the Communists stood not upon the extreme left, but upon the extreme right." This idea of Proles being expendable is furthered by Winston casually kicking a severed prole hand into the gutter after another bomb falling. This is symbolic of the true impacts of the war ; the party workers face no consequences from it, however the proles bear the brunt of the losses, and their suffering is swept under the carpet without a second thought to further the party's own power over the masses, something that is integrated into the subconscious of all their members as evidenced by Winston's lack of compassion at the sight of dead Proles.

This entire region has a dichotomous representation about it, as allegorically these Proles are leading what would be fairly average lives in Orwell's time, but in 1984's world, they're regarded as sub-human and looked down upon by everyone, including Winston. The pathological connections of this section with the readers is clear, due to the relatability, as well as shock at the treatment and different perspective on them. Without the telescreen present at the collector's house, Winston's personality seemed to clash more with the party's doctrines, appreciating the beauty of the Proles instead of only regarding them as "rubbish" ; the "curious silence" in the room without a telescreen is representative of Winston having the rare luxury of having thinking space for himself to indulge in humanity's naturally "curious" state in "silence" without the party's propaganda poisoning his thoughts, making it almost paraprosdokian that a setting of such underlying filth is evocative of almost 'human' behaviour and thinking.

Through this setting, Orwell creates a juxtaposition between the Inner and Outer Party where the totalitarian influence is more pronounced, and the Proles where it is much more minimal as they are regarded as sub-human. Orwell uses the Proles as a symbol to communicate to his readers that the very essence of what makes us human will be in danger and turned undesirable under a totalitarian regime.

Sanctuary

Pub

Orwell furthers the idea of totalitarianism posing grave dangers to society through his depiction of various forms of sanctuary in this novel's settings. We witness a pub in the prole slums, and throughout the setting of this place, Orwell's personal and cultural contexts as a frequent British pub-goer bear subtle influences to the general imagery painted for the audience. The regime's ingrained perspective is clearly visible through Winston's description of the pubs, another point of Orwell communicating the danger of a totalitarian society brainwashing citizens of recreation and basic pleasures. This is in Orwell's real world context, a space of comfort, happiness, and socialising ; all against the party's values, thus being taught to be regarded as beneath 'humans' to Winston and those in the Party.

Orwell uses the adjective "dingy", an implicit comment on not just the pub itself, but the lives of the proles as a whole, furthering the superiority of Winston and the party in comparison to them.

Furthermore, he also creates imagery by describing the pub having “windows [that] appeared to be frosted over but in reality were merely coated with dust”, again carrying connotations beyond the pub itself, implying that the proles as a community have a lot of potential, despite their suffering and ensuing “frosted” nature to foreign elements ; they just require unearthing the truths instead of the party’s “coating of dust” in their minds, created by their relentless propaganda.

This also forms a parallel to influential global events from Orwell’s lifetime, as he has seen firsthand the cold hearted, and “frosted” evil that people are capable of when their minds gather “dust” in a totalitarian society, having been a part of the Imperial force in Burma. At the pub, Winston recounts what they’ve been taught about the world before the ‘Revolution’ in the history books regarding the proposed ‘evil’ in the old world ; ‘the capitalists’, as “they owned everything there was to own.” and those under them “worked twelve hours a day”. Orwell’s irony here is directly reflective of his personal political learnings, portraying the communists and capitalists lambasting each other whilst shown to be acting in the exact same manners, as the Party does everything that Winston has been taught the “evil capitalists” did. This implies a perversion of the deepest kind, as Winston, the symbol of an everyday thoughtful citizen in a society, has had the sanctuary of his mind breached by the Party, being unable to rationalise through the propaganda, depicting the danger a totalitarian society poses to the sanctity of our own minds.

Golden Country

Orwell explores the theme of sanctuary from a different avenue, one of nature, using the nature clearing's setting as a juxtaposition to the bleak and foreboding nature of the rest of the places depicted in this world. Highlighting this place as a true sanctuary with minimal Party influence allows him to explore the freeing and beautiful primal instincts of humanity itself that the party has suppressed in much of the population. This idea of nature being an idyllic sanctuary stems from Orwell's own childhood, as beginning from a young age "he was a fairly practical, rural naturalist" **[Bissell],** and a passionate conservationist. The setting here is also directly reflective of many lives, those of the Party members', Orwell's own, as well as anyone else in the world, with safety in concealment, and unexpected dives into pleasure or pain being motifs throughout their everyday lives. This establishes ethos by creating relatability for his audience, and pathologically tugging at their own personal experiences to emphasise the impact of his implicit message in this section, Orwell giving some of his own childhood to the audience through this setting too. He implicitly communicates that humanity survives on hope, created by moral victories in the form of fleeting moments of human freedom, personal connection, and consciousness, which in this totalitarian society are moments so rare as to be obsolete.

Here, Winston's privacy, sense of self, as well as his appreciation of the world around him all came rushing back to him in this clearing. The sunlight was used by Orwell as a metaphor of the extent of the surveillance of the Party, as it's effects were still "hot on their faces", but "filtering through innumerable leaves", creating an idyllic view of nature and its protection of life in its truest form, pathologically convincing the readers of the sanctity of this setting. Winston's subsequent "curious, slow shock of recognition" indicates just how long he has gone without

truly experiencing nature, which while all around him, goes unnoticed, due to the Party bearing an oppressive force on his mental and emotional faculties, therefore this ‘new’ consciousness takes time to sink in. This clearing is in many ways like Winston’s personal journal, which he uses to escape briefly to a different world without the totalitarian force attacking his humanity with a vengeance, evidenced by his realisation that “it’s the Golden Country - almost.”

The Golden Country is a motif established by Orwell, as it is the setting of Winston’s earlier dream, where he took pleasure in deepening his connection to Julia, also symbolised by the bird in the pasture, implying freedom for them both. This bird is symbolic of what Winston wants to be, able to freely soar to the Golden Country, same as Orwell himself, as later in his life he was someone “who yearned for the Golden Country of his childhood” **[Bissell]** ; while Winston was bound by totalitarianism, Orwell was bound by his fatal tuberculosis **[McCrum]**. This creates a subtle commentary on a totalitarian society being like a disease, posing a danger to another element of humanity by leaching dreams and aspirations.

Furthermore, Orwell also explores the connection between Julia and Winston through the setting’s symbolism. The trees’ branches are symbolic of their opinions and beliefs being different, but sharing the same roots, that of the Party’s negative totalitarian impacts on their lives. Another related symbol is introduced as well furthering this notion, that of two different coloured flowers, connoting the individuality that they’re able to amicably explore in this safe setting away from the fatal surveillance of the party, something so primally beautiful, that Winston believed it would only be “seen in a dream”. Orwell uses this clearing to didactically and pathologically impress upon the reader, just how much of human connection the totalitarian

society takes away, and how under such a regime, it is next to impossible for most of humanity to ‘bloom’, like nature does.

Cafe

Chestnut Tree Cafe is a social space for individuals who’ll be “unquestionably vaporised”, as Winston foresees with his colleague Syme. The chestnut tree symbolises chastity, honesty, and justice, and since it is full of Party propaganda, it connotes the same for the Party. Orwell uses this irony to communicate that in the name of justice, honesty, and other inherently good values, the Party, like any totalitarian regime, betrays humanity. This setting carries intersectionality between the themes of sanctuary and power, exploring the idea that this crafted sanctuary of the cafe is merely a ploy by the Party to further their own power.

This notion is furthered by the diction of the singing in the background, "under the spreading chestnut tree, I sold you and you sold me". Since Winston symbolises humanity in this novel, whilst the party symbolises Totalitarianism, drawing another parallel to Orwell’s real world context, since in the wars he’s seen, various people have betrayed each other, and by extension “sold” their own humanity for money, implying that the capitalists’ greed for money is not the answer to the world’s problems anymore than the communists’ flawed sense of equality is, linking to Orwell’s interpretation of extremism in the form of totalitarianism being dangerous to humanity irrespective of the political spectrum **[The Orwell Foundation]**.

Winston's subconscious inscription of "2 + 2 = 5" on the table's dust is a terrifying image for Orwell's readers, the dust being metaphorical for his now scattered resistance, communicating a certain defeat of humanity under a totalitarian society through the subjugation of the symbol of Winston, emphasising the limitless power of the Party. Furthermore this links to the uncertainty we as readers have regarding the timeline of this world, as Winston believes it to be 1984, however Orwell does not give explicit insight into the matter, emphasising the Ingsoc Party's extreme manipulation of history. This is another implicit commentary on the threat a totalitarian society poses, achieving eternal dominance by eradicating notions as fundamental as time.

Government

Ministries

The power that the Ingsoc Party wields over Oceania is essential to Orwell's underlying messages in this novel, presented through various settings. For instance, The four main structures housing the Party's four ministries are the most prominent in the city's infrastructure. The names of the departments in each of the ministries are intentionally designed to be misnomers, on the surface seemingly the exact opposite of their purpose in truth. The Ministry of Love manages law and punishment, the Ministry of Peace regulates war, the Ministry of Plenty controls rationing, and the Ministry of Truth is in charge of propaganda. These various ironic landscapes heighten the readers' sense of dread, defeat and fear in the face of the bureaucratic and political power that rules them. The real world settings in London from George Orwell's time of writing

are subtly alluded to as well, with landmarks like St. Clement's Church being portrayed as a ruin in this new world. The Party's purpose through the creation of these ministries appears to be to control people's very conscious existence, by manipulating their thoughts in order to suit the Ingsoc agendas. This is largely done through various technologies used by the Party workers of the ministries.

Technology

Orwell incorporates technology from his time of writing into the world of 1984, especially from a military standpoint where he had firsthand knowledge regarding many **[The Orwell Foundation]**. From what we observe, technologies like tanks, trucks, airplanes, leg irons are all fairly similar to their alluded points of reference in the real world. However, to suit the futuristic and different political context of his novel, Orwell also incorporates fictional technologies used by the Ingsoc party throughout the novel. The Telescreen, as aforementioned, is symbolic of the party's power and influence. However there are also the automated 'Versificators' and 'Memory Holes', fiction generators used by the Ministry of Truth and incineration slots used in the Ministry of Truth to burn outdated propaganda, respectively. The use of automated technology is symbolic of the totalitarian society's impact on the population, turning them into mere pawns for the party to exploit like common tools for the furthering of their own agenda, again showcasing their endless power, and almost mechanically sapping away any resistance or free thought. The imagery of these machines literally shaping the future, present, and past is terrifying, furthering Orwell's message of the threats that totalitarianism poses to human control of society.

Power (‘Big Brother’ and Torture Chambers)

A figurehead dictator of the ‘Big Brother’ is also created by the Party for the purposes of pathos and ethos to more effectively subjugate the society. The omniscient pseudo-presence of this totalitarian dictator, is seen by the countless posters carrying messages of “Big Brother is watching you”, furthering the suffocatingly malicious atmosphere of this country through a passive-aggressive tone. Orwell’s caricature of Big Brother is reminiscent of Stalin and Hitler **[Wilber]**, drawing parallels between novel oppressions in this fictional world, to events that have already taken place in the real world.

He further alludes to the concentration camps of Nazi Germany, and the Gulags of the Societ Union, through torture spaces for “treatment” and “reintegration” like the notorious Room 101 for the regime to further assert their power on the dissenters in this society. Winston being placed in a “cell with no windows” symbolises the earlier foreshadowed inevitability of the Party’s power overcoming any resistance that humanity, symbolised through Winston, could put up. Orwell implies the Party’s, and by extension, totalitarianism’s goal is eradicating the essence of humanity, calling it a “stain to be wiped out”.

Orwell connotes that these torture chambers are ultimately symbolic of the Party’s power, and ‘illumination’ that they intend to force upon everyone in the population, working towards their goal of conquering people’s minds and spirits. This can be seen in Orwell’s diction and construed semantic field of overwhelming power through phrases like “place where there is no darkness”, with its “mighty corridors” and “dazzling golden lights”, connoting absolute, brutal, and painstaking dominion over humanity. An implicit commentary is thus formed, communicating

another of Orwell's underlying messages in this novel, exploring the parallel of dangers of totalitarian regimes to our world's societies, eerily reminiscent of the fictional world he has created, wherein the power of a totalitarian society threatens humanity as a whole, skewing our existence by compromising the very idea of home, and eradicating any modicum of happiness or human spirit present in a sanctuary.

Conclusion

In answer to the research question, **'How does Orwell use setting to communicate the dangers of a totalitarian society?',** The setting of the world depicted in 1984 assists Orwell in achieving his broader purpose, painting an intrinsically oppressive picture, showing various parallels to the real world. Orwell's settings not only show the dangers of a totalitarian society ; they communicate the fragility of ideals important to us ; through the compromise of home, and the vulnerability of our sanctuaries in the face of totalitarian power. Orwell's message resonates beyond the confines of his era, for as long as humanity exists, there will be a scramble for power, in which any version of totalitarianism is a plausible future, posing an existential threat to society : the demise of what makes us human.

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